



Landmines in cyberspace

In most cases, threats creep into a computer's hard drive by piggy-backing onto the software programs we download. They can also sneak in through security gaps in web browsers when unsuspecting users visit certain sites or use open Wi-Fi networks

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Rajat Sharma had to spend a weekend apologising to friends for accidentally sharing with PDF files that were infected with adware. An avid book reader, Rajat was looking for ebook readers on the net, and he managed to download few pirated editions from a web site. When he opened

the downloaded books on his computer, he was asked to update his Flash player. He did that unthinkingly and got the adware downloaded into his system. When he shared these digital books with his friends, they too got a similar requests for updating their Flash players and fell for it.

"We were hit with dizzying - and nearly unstoppable - onslaughts of pop-up ads," says Rajat. "It was really frustrating. My system also slowed down. My friends suffered the same fate, and blamed me for the mess." The problem in this case was aggravated by the fact that none of them were using anti-virus systems. A majority of PCs in India continue to run pirated Windows systems, without protection and easily fall prey to the nefarious designs of malicious coders. Rajat and his friends were ultimately able to get rid of the adware by using the free HouseCall facility from Trend Micro, one of world's major creators of software tools for safeguarding the integrity of com-

puter systems from all kinds of threats.

No one can deny the importance of the internet, but it is also true that the cyberspace is like a battlefield strewn with

Security tip of the month

A Keylogger is a program that is capable of tracking and transmitting the keys struck on the keyboard of any computer system. If such a program were to infect your system, then the hacker would be able to get access to the passwords of every account that you access. They might be able to steal money from your bank or credit card account. The best way of removing a Key logger from you system is to run a good anti-spyware program. You can also go in for a comprehensive online scan. If you have a Windows based system, then Windows Live OneCare (<http://onecare.live.com>) might turn out to be a good option. This free service is only available if you are using a genuine Windows operating system.